

CG Animation, Neurodiversity and Autistic College Students

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1 INTRODUCTION

For many college students with autism, art and animation are strengths to pursue. However, the teaching methods to best accommodate autistic artists may differ. With growing numbers of students registered with campus Office of Disability and Accessibility Services (ODAS), what does it mean for a university to truly support animation and visual effects students in the neurodiverse community?

Jennifer E. Drake of the Department of Psychology at Boston College hypothesized that “evidence has shown that not only are many children with autism spectrum (ASD) highly intelligent, demonstrating creative and cognitive abilities that far exceed those of their non-ASD peers, but autistic children are also better able to process details than other children. In many tests, autistic children outperform their peers on local processing tasks, or tasks that require identification of parts of a whole. This is especially true when there are clear delineations between the individual segments of a global picture.” [Drake, 2012]

Working as a professional animator or visual effects artist in a studio typically entails showing work in dailies and receiving frequent constructive feedback with tight deadlines and the ability to address numerous retakes. Receiving feedback from one's peers in the university classroom is a typical requirement to prepare students for real-world professional settings, yet constructive feedback and evaluation may be difficult for neurodiverse students. Faculty may need alternative techniques in the classroom but may not have adequate

or appropriate training in this area. How do college level educators best support large neurodiverse and autistic populations while simultaneously meeting learning outcomes and moving the program forward? How do small universities with very limited resources achieve these goals? Learning about the differences between high school and college-level accommodations have contributed to a better understanding of the kinds of support both students and faculty need in the classroom. The presenters in sections 2, 3 and 4 have worked with many autistic artists over decades and will discuss differing classrooms, learning styles and modes of teaching.

2 AGENCY FOR CIVIC ENGAGEMENT AT WOODBURY UNIVERSITY

The Agency for Civic Engagement (ACE) at Woodbury University empowers students to improve underserved communities through design, business and media. ACE connects students and faculty with nonprofit and governmental organizations to realize projects for the public. Students work collaboratively across disciplines to combine skills and test their fields of study on real projects and local issues. Reinforcing the capacity of young generations to create impact, ACE projects are made to benefit the common good: animated PSAs, graphic design, architectural design/build works, journalistic and creative writing, and other services. Framing opportunities to make a difference, ACE supports student learning through inclusive and socially equitable research, outreach, and engagement.

3 COLLEGE AUTISM SPECTRUM

Students with autism often have no trouble meeting the entrance criteria to the college of their choice, yet once there, have extreme difficulty navigating the academic and social complexities inherent in the college experience. Many lack the self-management skills needed to independently organize and integrate all aspects of college life. Stress of transition can inhibit a student's ability to know who and when to ask for help.

College Autism Spectrum (CAS) is an independent organization of professionals whose purpose is to assist students with autism, and their families. They specialize in college counseling (helping students find the right college) and work/career readiness (skill building for interviews, jobs and work skills).

They help autistic students explore and navigate college options before, during and through the college process. Additionally, they provide campuses and professionals with the tools and training to work effectively with students on the spectrum and to understand the challenges as well as the talents they bring.

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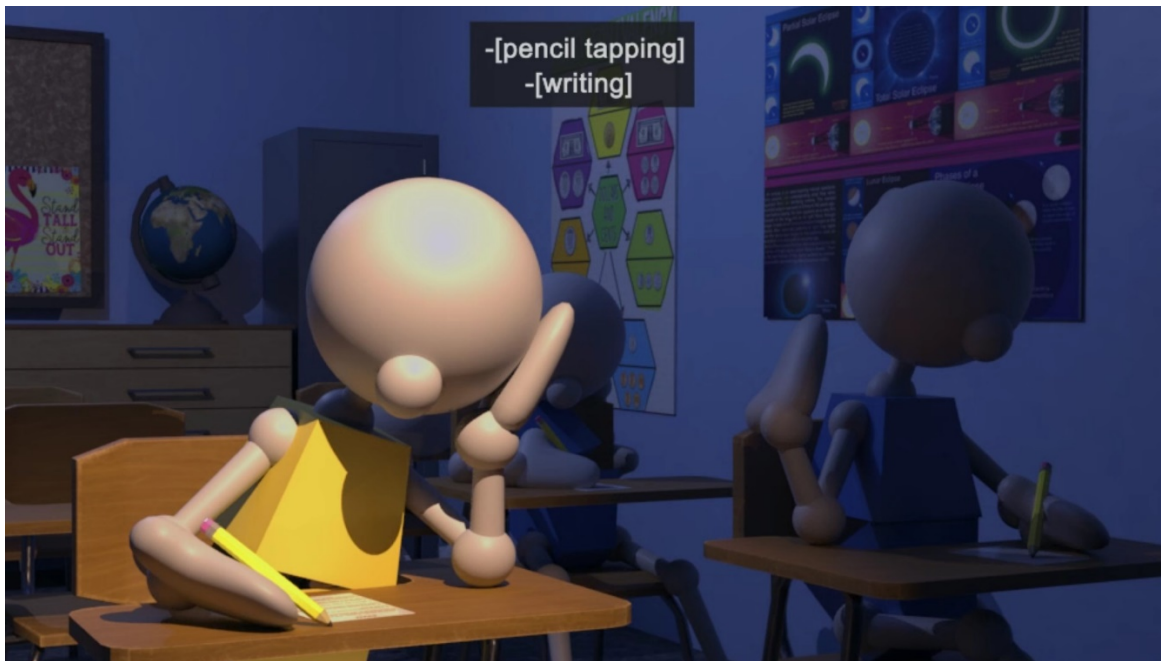


Figure 1: Final rendered image from CG animated PSA for College Autism Spectrum and Mosaic from Woodbury University's Fall 2023 Civic Engagement course on Introduction to 3D Animation. ©Isabella Willet and Guillermo Velazquez Aguiar.

4 THE MOSAIC PROGRAM AT THE UNIVERSITY OF TENNESSEE

The Mosaic program is made up of four primary components. Each of these works in concert with the others to provide a comprehensive program. These components include: a credit-bearing course with a fully established curriculum with a letter grade attached, coaching, peer/professional mentoring, and supervised study hours. The curriculum is written and structured based on the latest research in the field.

Creatively re-imagining how to best support a campus culture of inclusivity while understanding legal compliance and research trends will truly support and empower students with disabilities,

specifically neurodivergence, into all aspects of campus life. Classroom management is essential in order to accomplish all these goals. This session will provide tools for implementation in the college classroom.

Developing the necessary skills to navigate a college animation and visual effects curriculum and hopeful employment in the field may require support for some students. Educating the faculty and the campus community about the needs of neurodivergent students assists everyone on campus.

REFERENCES

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